

TITLE: TAKE ME BACK TO THE NIGHT WE MET

INT. The Hallway - DAY

The usually quiet hallway of the apartment is filled with sounds of cardboard scraping along the floor. The hallway is filled with many boxes and suitcases of varying sizes. A girl, Meera, in her 20s, is trying to drag them all inside her flat, struggling and making slow progress.

She is in the process of tugging a particularly big box across the hallway as the door next to her flat opens. Out steps another girl, Aarna. She is carrying a trash bag in her right hand, and the other rests in her pocket. Her hair is messy, a tired expression on her face. She walks past all the boxes, eyeing them as she steps over a box in the way. She looks at Meera and smiles

AARNA

Hello, Good morning

MEERA

Good Morning!

Aarna nods and goes into the lift at the end of the hallway. In a few minutes, Aarna returns, and though Meera made some progress, she's still tugging the same big box. Aarna looks at her again, and awkwardly tries to walk past. She's near her flat, hand on the knob, she hesitates. She looks back at Meera and sighs and walks over.

AARNA

Uhm, do you need any help with your stuff?

MEERA

Oh, I- if you don't mind then, yes, please!

Meera sounds relieved as she says that. They both tug the big box inside the house. The flat inside is empty and run-down. A few corners of the walls were damp from what is likely a plumbing leak, and the others had peeling, flaky paint due to overpainting them. The floorboards were a little creaky but not anything really dilapidated. They pull the cardboard box in, and huff.

MEERA

I'm really sorry, you didn't have to do this.

AARNA

Technically, I offered my help

MEERA

Still, I could've refused

AARNA

Don't worry. I don't mind.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - DAY

They continue pulling boxes and suitcases in. The clock reads 1:26 PM. They sit on the ground, surrounded by cardboard boxes, visibly tired. They just sit in silence for a while before Aarna gets up. Seeing this, Meera also sits up.

MEERA

Thank you so much again for your help. It'd have taken a lot longer if you hadn't helped.

AARNA

Again, don't mention it. I needed to distract myself and procrastinate on my assignments, so this helped a lot.

Aarna shoots her a thumbs up, causing both of them to laugh

MEERA (groaning)

I'll return this favour sometime in the futur-

AARNA

Girl, what you need to worry about right now is getting this house right and having something to sit on.

Meera laughs sheepishly.

AARNA

Do you need any more help? Water?

MEERA

Oh no no! What you've done is more than enough. Thanks though.

AARNA

Also, there's a good fast food place down the street. You might wanna eat and then get back to unpacking.

MEERA

No time for that. I really need to get everything in order by tonight. First day at my new job tomorrow.

AARNA (hums in agreement)

I see, but eat something

Aarna waves at her as she walks to the door and pulls it open and walks out, before popping her head back in.

AARNA

Also, the knob will come loose in a few days, so I suggest replacing it. And the lights flickered a lot when I first came in. You should get them fixed too.

MEERA

Ah, could I get your number then? In case I need to ask you about anything?

AARNA

Yeah sure.

Aarna comes back into the threshold of the house. They open their phones and share their numbers. Aarna walks back to the door again, waving, this time a bit hesitantly. Meera returns the wave and smiles. Aarna closes the door, and it clicks, locking itself. Meera sighs and looks around at the mess around her. Then suddenly the doorknob turns and rattles, and a knock echoes around the empty walls of the house. Before Meera could go and open the door, a voice comes from the other side, muffled.

AARNA

I'm Aarna

MEERA(smiles)

I'm Meera

AARNA

I live right next door, by the way

MEERA(laughs)

I figured.

AARNA

Right

Meera smiles as a laugh sounds behind the closed door. She hears her retreating footsteps and turns back to her mess and sighs again.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - NIGHT

Meera is just done with unpacking most of her boxes. She puts away the final flattened cardboard box in the corner and looks around. Only two suitcases are left. She sighs, happy, and sits on the couch, taking all her work in. She groans as her tummy rumbles.

Getting up, she walks to her door, puts on her shoes, and opens the doorknob. When she pulls the door open, a takeout bag hangs on the doorknob and rattles against the door. She picks it up, and the containers are still warm under her fingers. There's a sticky note attached to it.

"You're welcome ;)"

— Aarna

She smiles, looks at the 507 door, and walks back into her flat, staring at the note. She shuffles out of her shoes and walks to the table. She takes the note off and puts it on the table.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - DAY

Meera is looking at herself in the mirror, brushing at her formal wear, nervous. She huffs out a breath, trying to calm herself. She grabs her bag, rummaging through it, checking if she's got everything. She exits her room

INT. Apartment Hallway - DAY

Meera exits the apartment and is locking her door and startles as the door to flat 507 shoots open with a bang. She sees Aarna, her hair in a braid but still messy, one of her hands busy with a notebook as the other struggles to put her shoes on. Aarna barely notices Meera as she walks over to the lift. Meera joins Aarna by her side and looks at her. She hesitates a bit before saying

MEERA
Thanks

AARNA (distracted)
Hm?

MEERA
For the takeout?

AARNA
Ah right. Did you like it?

MEERA
Yeah, thanks for that.

They fall into silence for a while as the lift chimes. They both step in. Meera looks at the notebook in Aarna's hand.

MEERA
Exam prep?

AARNA
Yep

MEERA
What subject?

AARNA
Probability and Statistics

MEERA
Sounds difficult

AARNA
Trust me, it is.

Aarna looks at Meera, taking in her formal attire.

AARNA
New job, right?

MEERA
Mhm, Gallery Assistant.

AARNA
Don't know what that is, but damn girl, good for you.

MEERA (laughs)

Just making sure people don't touch stuff they're not supposed to and explaining stuff to them. Pretty good actually.

AARNA

Speak for yourself. I wouldn't survive speaking to people every day.

Meera laughs at her, and steps out of the lift as the lift chimes.
They walk to the gate of the apartment

MEERA

Good luck on that exam.

AARNA

Thank you. And you too.

They go their separate ways.

INT. Apartment Hallway - EVENING

Meera walks out of the lift, shoulders slumping as she walks along the hallway to her flat before she stops, perplexed by Aarna just lying on the floor outside her door.

MEERA (worried)

Aarna? Are you okay?

AARNA

I left the heater on this morning

MEERA (laughs)

How do you even - For how long?

AARNA

I will not be answering that

Meera laughs out loud and comes to sit next to Aarna, slightly nudging her with her hand.

MEERA

Don't lie down. It's dirty

AARNA (groaning)

Fine, Mom

They sit in silence for a while before Meera speaks up

MEERA

So, how was the exam today?

AARNA (exasperated)

Don't even ask. That was genuinely the worst exam I've ever taken in my life

MEERA

Jeez, that bad?

AARNA

Everything about engineering is bad. It's like they come as a package deal

MEERA

Oh, you study engineering?

AARNA

Mhm

MEERA

What do you like about it?

AARNA (humourless laugh)

I don't like it.

MEERA

Oh? Then why do it?

AARNA

I don't know

MEERA

So you like something else?

AARNA

I don't know

MEERA

You definitely do. What is it?

AARNA

I- I don't know, not engineering.

MEERA

Are you embarrassed of what you like?

She smiles a bit as Aarna ducks her head in slight embarrassment and nudges her with her elbow.

MEERA

Ey, come on. I won't judge. Unless, of course, it's gambling or something

Aarna laughs, but is quick to change the subject.

AARNA

Oh, I forgot, how was your first day?

MEERA

People are horrible.

AARNA (laughs)

I told you

MEERA

Not only are they horrible, they're *dumb*. A guy told his son that dinosaurs aren't real.

AARNA (through laughter)

What?

MEERA

HE SAID DINOSAURS AREN'T REAL!! Where do these people come from, I swear.

AARNA

(laughs) This is only the start

MEERA

Oh definitely. A man yelled at me cuz I told him he couldn't buy a painting. I started panicking man. I just stood there

Aarna starts laughing out loud as Meera finishes recounting her story.

AARNA

Sounds like you'll be having really interesting things to tell your kids one day.

Meera's smile falls for a second before she smiles again, but this one doesn't quite reach her face. Aarna notices and turns to look away, staring at the floor.

MEEERA (clearing throat)
I'll need to get started on dinner. See you around?

AARNA
Mhm, bye. I'll stay out here for a while longer.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - EVENING

They wave each other goodbye, and Meera enters her apartment and closes it shut. She stares into the nothingness of her apartment, and her smile slowly starts fading away. She stares into the empty apartment, looking around, and her eyes slowly start welling up with tears and fall freely on her face. She is quick to wipe them off, annoyed, and shoves off her work heels and walks into the apartment.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - EVENING

It is a Sunday afternoon. The clock reads 3 PM as Meera is in the kitchen baking cookies. Quick cuts of the sun outside the window, the clock, and the baking process. Meera sits at the table reading an article on her laptop as the oven timer dings.

She looks at the time and gets up, heading over to the oven. She opens it and fans them for a while. She starts picking the cookies up one by one and fills her cookie jar. When she's around 3/4th of the way through, she looks at the cookies and ponders for a while before smiling. She takes another box from her kitchen cupboards and fills it up with the rest of the cookies.

She puts it in a small brown paper bag and grabs her phone from the table. She opens the door of her apartment, sighing a bit as the doorknob is a little loose. Meera makes her way to the flat next to hers and rings the bell. She waits for a little while, bag in hand as she looks around aimlessly.

When the door doesn't open for a while, she looks slightly dejected and is about to leave when the door swings open, revealing a

sleepy-faced Aarna. Aarna looks at Meera and then at the bag, confused

MEERA

Oh, did I wake you? I can come by another time

AARNA (yawns)

Nah, don't worry about it. I needed to get work done anyway. (pause)
What's that?

Meera looks down at her hands and lifts the bag, momentarily forgetting why she was there in the first place.

MEERA

I made too many cookies. Thought I'd share

AARNA

There's no such thing as too many cookies.

MEERA (lowering the bag)

Will you take them or do you want me to eat them all?

AARNA (laughs and takes the bag)

Are you threatening me?

They stand near Aarna's doorway for a while, before Aarna's eyebrows shoot up, realising where they are.

AARNA

Oh right. I totally forgot. Come inside.

MEERA (hesitant)

You sure? You just said you had some work to get to.

AARNA

Don't worry about that. Make yourself at home.

MEERA

If you say so.

INT. Aarna's Flat (507) - EVENING

Meera enters Aarna's flat, which looks just like hers, but her walls are painted deep blue, and white furniture and decor items. The wall

opposite the small TV is full of photo frames, ranging from pictures of Aarna's childhood to scenic photography. Meera stares at them for a while, taking them in, smiling to herself, only to be interrupted by the noises Aarna makes as she tries to balance two plates, the cookie bag, a bottle of juice, and two glasses in her two hands. Meera rushes to help her.

MEERA
Careful.

AARNA
Thanks

They both sit on the fluffy couch in the living room, putting the snacks on the table. Meera sees Aarna divide the cookies amongst the two of them and frowns.

MEERA
Hey, I bought those cookies for you to enjoy.

AARNA
Well, all good things taste better when shared with people.

MEERA
You just made that up

AARNA
Did not!

Meera rolls her eyes, not unkindly, and takes a cookie. She bites into it and laughs when Aarna furrows her eyebrows and chews aggressively.

AARNA
Oh my god, these are the best cookies I've ever tasted in my life.
What the hell.

MEERA (smug)
Hm, what can I say? My hands are magic

AARNA
That they definitely are.

Meera laughs again and looks around the house again.

MEERA

I love what you've done with the house. The colours go along so well.

AARNA

Aw, thank you. Half this stuff I stole from my flatmate.

MEERA (startled laugh)

Glad we don't share a flat then

Meera points at the pictures on the wall.

MEERA

Those pictures up there, did you take them?

Aarna's eyes follow her hand and she gives a small sheepish smile,
almost bashful.

AARNA

Kinda.

MEERA

How do you kinda take a picture?

AARNA

I meant I took a few of them. The others are from my childhood, so
obviously I didn't take them.

MEERA

Hmmm, you've definitely got an eye for taking good pictures.

AARNA

They're okay at best.

MEERA

Really? Cuz I see them framed. On a wall. (pause) I really love the
moon one.

Meera points at the one in the right corner. It's a frame of a
picture of a moon, framed by branches protruding from the nearby
trees.

AARNA

Hmm, that's my favourite too.

MEERA (lights up)
Oh my god, I just had an idea. You should come over to the museum sometime. We could use a good photographer who knows what they're doing.

AARNA
First of all, I don't *do* photography-

MEERA
You have a wall full of it.

AARNA
-Secondly, I'll be lucky if I get to sleep for a good few hours after doing all my classes and assignments.

MEERA (deflates a bit)
Ah right. I forgot about that.

AARNA (hesitant)
But... I'll try to make time for this.

MEERA (smiles)
Alright.

CUT.

INT. Building Laundry Room - EVENING

Meera is huffing, unloading all her laundry into her basket, when she hears footsteps behind her. She turns back and sees Aarna. She smiles at her, closes the door of the washing machine, and starts walking away when Aarna calls to her.

AARNA
You dropped something

Meera turns back and sees one of her black socks lying on the floor. She lets out a little "oh" and goes back to pick it up.

AARNA
Is that your sock?

MEERA

Yeah?

AARNA

Why is it black?

MEERA

Cuz it's a sock.

AARNA

Jeez, you're boring

MEERA (deadpan)

It's a sock.

Aarna lifting a bright blue and orange sock from her basket

MEERA

Gosh, what the hell is that?

AARNA

What, are you allergic to colour or something?

MEERA

Nope, you took my share too.

AARNA

Ha ha. Very funny.

Meera smiles and shakes her head and walks away, leaving Aarna to do her laundry.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - EVENING

The sun is almost setting outside the window. It's been a week or two since Meera moved into the apartment. She is in the kitchen, cleaning up after cooking her dinner, and absentmindedly humming a song. She continues humming and wiping the counter, and without realising it, she begins singing the lyrics.

Slowly, her volume increases, and she's properly singing the song. While she's in the middle of the chorus of the song, she hears a piano playing distantly. She registers after a second or two that it's the same tune as the song she was just singing.

Meera stops singing, and the piano notes still hang in the air for a few seconds before stopping. She begins singing again, and after a few lines, the piano begins too. Meera walks along the house, trying to find out where the music is coming from, when suddenly, a distant, slightly off-key voice also starts singing along to her and the piano.

Meera realises the voice is coming from the other side of the wall, Aarna's flat, and stops singing. The singing and piano die down too. Meera inches closer to the wall and puts her ear to the wall, trying to see if she can hear anything. She detaches herself, brows furrowed, and calls out to Aarna

MEERA
...Aarna?

AARNA (startled)
Oh- Meera? Is that you?

MEERA
Uh huh. Were you the one singing along?

AARNA
Singing along? That was you? I thought I left a song playing on my phone

MEERA
Nope. Who knew the walls were this thin?

AARNA
Not me. You sing really well by the way.

MEERA (bashful)
Ah thanks. You're not so bad yourself

AARNA
Oh cut it. I know I sound like a dying rat.

MEERA
...

AARNA
You're not even gonna deny it?

MEERA
(laughs) Sorry but-

AARNA
Don't even!

(silence)

AARNA
Man, this is so weird. We're having a conversation and not even see each other.

MEERA
I know, right.

AARNA
This is just a little off-putting.

MEERA
Why?

AARNA
Cuz you can hear everything I do?

MEERA
But I couldn't the past few weeks, though. Maybe it depends on the volume and how close to the wall we are.

AARNA
Makes sense. I'm literally stuck to the wall right now.

MEERA
(laughs) Starfish.

AARNA
Hey, you're also leaning on the wall to talk to me.

MEERA
Right.

AARNA
Do you wanna continue singing? It was fun. Like a karaoke at home.

MEERA
Sure, if you want me to.

AARNA

Okay, wait, let me get to my piano.

Meera hears her scurry off to the piano and smiles when she hears the notes float in the air. She turns her back to the wall and leans against it as she starts singing again. The song ends after a while, and Meera just stays there, leaning against the wall. After a beat of silence, she says

AARNA
Wall Karaoke.

MEERA
What?

AARNA
I'm naming whatever we just did. Wall Karaoke

MEERA (laughs)
Seriously?

AARNA
Yeah. It suits it, right?

MEERA
Sure, I guess.

(silence)

AARNA
We should do this again sometime.

MEERA (through laughter)
The Wall Karaoke?

AARNA
Mhm, 'twas the most fun I had in a while.

MEERA
(hums) Yeah sure, why not.

AARNA
So, was that your favourite song or?

MEERA
Nah, just something that was stuck in my head. I like sad songs.

AARNA

Is your overall vibe being depressed or something? Like even your socks are black.

MEERA

Socks are socks! They are supposed to be black, not whatever the hell you wear

AARNA

Sure grandma. I like Måneskin by the way.

MEERA

Rock? Of course you'd like rock.

AARNA

What does that mean?

MEERA

I don't know. Vibes.

AARNA

Oh wow, you know what that word means, grandma?

MEERA

I'm not that old!

AARNA

Oh yeah? How old are you?

MEERA

Only 27

AARNA

Oh wow, Grandma

MEERA

How old are you then?

AARNA

23

MEERA

We're basically the same age.

AARNA

Don't you put me in the same age range as you

Meera smiles as she hears giggles coming from the other side of the wall. Silence falls between them, and Aarna suddenly groans.

AARNA

Ughh I'm bored. Tell me something.

MEERA

What do you want me to say?

AARNA

I don't know, something. Like, what's your favorite movie?

MEERA

Uhh, it's this old movie. Called Ponette.

AARNA

Ooo, what's it about?

MEERA

It's about this little girl who loses her mother in an accident, and she kinda learns how to live life after that and stuff.

AARNA

Jeez, even the movies you watch are depressing

MEERA

Hey!

(silence)

Are you not gonna tell me your favourite movie?

AARNA

Nope.

MEERA

Ugh, you twat!

AARNA (laughs)

Have you ever heard of Spy Kids?

MEERA

Ooo I love that one!

They fall into silence again.

AARNA

You've got work tomorrow, right?

MEERA

Mhmm

AARNA

Good night then

MEERA

Good night Aarna

CUT

MONTAGE SCENES:

INT. Meera's Flat (506)- EVENING

Meera is on her laptop, glasses on as she's scrolling through an article, making notes in her notebook. Suddenly she hears a loud thump coming from the other side of the wall. She looks at it, confused, and goes back to her article. Another thump echoes, followed by one more, and a string of curses. She huffs an incredulous laugh and goes to the wall, knocks on it once, and calls out to Aarna.

MEERA

Everything alright over there?

AARNA

Yep.

MEERA

Really? Cuz it sounds like you're destroying your flat

AARNA

I just- the stupid printer isn't working, and I need to submit a report by tomorrow.

MEERA

Can you not fix it? You do study engineering.

AARNA

Ugh I- I was trying to fix it.

MEERA

By trying to beat the heck out of it?

AARNA (mumble)

It worked all the other times.

(pause)

AARNA

You don't happen to have a printer, do you?

MEERA

Nope, but I think I know how to fix one.

AARNA

Oh my god, you're a lifesaver!

MEERA

Mhm, and you're welcome.

INT. Meera's Flat (506)- EVENING

It is evening, the sun is setting. Meera enters her apartment, shoulders slouching, exhausted. She takes off her heels, drops her bag on the table, and collapses face down on the nearest couch. She lays there motionless for a few seconds. She hears music coming from the other wall.

The music is faint, Meera has to strain her ears to hear the lyrics. She turns to look at the wall. She makes her way off the couch and sits on the floor near the wall, back facing the wall. She brings up a hand and knocks on the concrete between them. At first there's nothing, but the volume of the music goes lower. She tries again. This time the music stops.

MEERA

Aarna, are you there?

AARNA

What's up?

MEERA

Can I just talk to you about something?

AARNA

Sure, go ahead.

MEERA

Work was shit.

(pause)

It was - I mean it probably was nothing compared to what other people experience daily-

AARNA

Hey, it made you feel like shit. So it was a big deal to you. So, let it out.

MEERA

We had a meeting today. All of us workers. I brought up an issue the visitors were having, and was dismissed. Literally just no one even heard me out properly. And I- okay, maybe it would've been fine if it ended with that, but no. And Aryan, did I ever tell you about Aryan?

He's the world number one asshole. Literally. Like, a few minutes after I mentioned the issue, he brought it up. The same exact issue, same exact wording. But guess what?

AARNA

What?

MEERA

They listened to him. They listened to every single thing he had to say and walked over me. And okay, still maybe that wouldn't have affected me that much, but Aryan? That little bitch. Every damn day he tries to make my life miserable.

AARNA

I'm sorry you had to deal with that.

MEERA

Oh, you haven't even heard the way he calls me, "sweetheart". I wanna gag every time he says that.

AARNA

Do you want advice or do you want me to call him an asshole?

MEERA

Call him an asshole

AARNA

He's an asshole.

They sit in silence for a while.

MEERA

Sorry for just dumping everything on you. You must've been busy

AARNA

Actually no, I wasn't. And don't apologize. I'd rather hear you talk about this stuff than just bottle it up.

(pause)

AARNA

Also, I have some leftover pizza from last night. Want some?

MEERA

Aarna, do you ever eat proper healthy food?

AARNA

Healthy food? What's that?

MEERA

Seriously. I'll start feeding you if you keep eating like that.

AARNA

Chill, babe, and also you haven't answered my question.

MEERA

What question?

AARNA

Pizza? Come over?

MEERA

Fine, I'll be there in five.

CUT

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - EVENING

Meera is in her living room, clearing out her bookshelf, cleaning the shelf, and rearranging the books. Suddenly, Aarna's voice comes from the other side of the wall.

AARNA
Meeraa, I'm bored.

MEERA
Hi, bored. I'm Meera

AARNA
Seriously? Anyway, what are you doing?

MEERA
Cleaning my bookshelf

AARNA
Whoa, a whole dang bookshelf?

MEERA
Don't worry, it's your size.

AARNA
Hey, what's that supposed to mean?

MEERA
Nothing nothing.

AARNA
So, you read?

MEERA
Generally that's why people get bookshelves, so yes.

AARNA
You're so annoying. What genre do you read?

MEERA
The whole lot. If it seems interesting, I read. What about you?

AARNA
Hm?

MEERA
Do you read?

(silence)

MEERA

Aarna?

AARNA

If you're talking about course materials, then yes.

MEERA (laughs)

You know what I mean.

AARNA

Uhh, I used to read. A while ago.

MEERA

Used to? How long ago?

AARNA

The last time I read an actual physical book was maybe 10th grade.

MEERA (almost drops a book)

10th grade??? That's like- Aarna, that's like 7 years ago.

AARNA

I know.

MEERA

Why'd you stop?

AARNA

Oh, you know. Engineering. JEE. The whole lot.

MEERA

Oh.

AARNA

Yeah, I mean, you know how parents get. I had to stop reading, writing, playing the piano- they even told me to step down from student council positions so I could focus more on the exams.

(pause)

AARNA

It was supposed to be temporary, until I got into college. But then came the workload. The assignments, projects, deadlines. And soon I just forgot about it.

MEERA

And did it work out?

AARNA

Did what work out?

MEERA

All that studying

AARNA (snorts)

Babe, if it did, I wouldn't be living in a rundown apartment with a barely filled fridge.

(silence)

MEERA

So you gave up all that... for engineering?

AARNA

Pretty much.

MEERA

Then you must hate it, don't you?

AARNA

Is that even a question?

MEERA

So what do you like?

AARNA

I... don't know

MEERA

Oh come on, you're tryna tell em you went 7 years without thinking of what you'd rather do instead of engineering?

AARNA

Uhm

(silence)

AARNA

I've always liked photography..

MEERA

That's great!

AARNA

But I've never been good at it, and it's not like it's gonna get me anywhere.

MEERA

Okay, first of all, that's a lie. You capture really good pictures like the stuff people walk by? You frame them and show it off.

AARNA

Okay, you don't have to-

MEERA

I'm not done. Secondly, when did someone have to be good at something to enjoy doing it? Not everyone was born Picassos or whatever. And thirdly, if you don't let yourself have this little hobby or whatever, how do you expect yourself to become better?

(silence)

AARNA

Damn, you sound like my mother.

MEERA

Aarna.

AARNA

I know.

MEERA

You like it, and that's enough.

AARNA

Yeah.

MEERA

Ugh, you sound so sad now. You want a brownie?

AARNA

You made brownies? And you didn't give me any?

Meera laughs.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - EVENING

Meera is sitting on her couch, watching TV, when she hears something heavy thunk against the wall. She turns to look at the wall, and she smiles.

MEERA

Did you just throw something at the wall?

AARNA (whining)

Meera

MEERA

What do you want?

AARNA

Wall Karaoke

MEERA

Now?

AARNA

Yeah, I'm sad

MEERA

Jeez fine. I'm coming.

Meera gets off her couch and goes to their spot on the floor. She sits down, back facing the wall, waiting for the notes of the piano to float through and smiling slightly when she recognizes the song. She opens her mouth and lets the lyrics fall out her mouth, voice thick and sweet like honey. Her smile widens when she hears Aarna

join in. They spent the next half hour just singing songs. They stop eventually.

MEERA
Better now?

AARNA
Much better.

(silence)

AARNA
Thanks

MEERA
Anytime.

AARNA
You know, we never actually hung out.

MEERA
We literally talk. Everyday. I don't think I even remember a night where we didn't.

AARNA
You know what I mean! In person.

MEERA
Fine fine. What do you wanna do?

AARNA
Movie? And maybe cook dinner? I don't know

MEERA
Yeah, we could do that.

AARNA
Tomorrow?

MEERA
Ughhh, sure.

INT. Aarna's Flat (507) - NIGHT

Meera is greeted with Aarna's smile as she opens the door. Meera steps into the flat and gets her sandals off. She holds a box of cookies, and she walks further into the apartment, following Aarna. The living room has the couch, a fluffy duvet, some mood lighting, and Netflix open. She puts the box on the table in the living room and walks into the kitchen. She opens the fridge door.

MEERA

Great, let's see what you've got in- what in the actual hell is this????

AARNA

What do you mean?

MEERA

Where's the food?

The fridge has a frozen pizza, leftover instant noodles, a singular tomato, and chips.

AARNA

What do you mean- oh.

MEERA

Child, do you eat??

AARNA

Uhm yes. I was supposed to restock for this, but I forgot.

MEERA

For this?? You mean to say if we weren't meeting today there'll be no proper food?

AARNA

Uhm

MEERA

Jeez, you're a lost cause.

Meera walks off into the living room and picks up the cookie box and her stuff

MEERA

We're going to my flat. You'll be properly fed tonight.

Meera huffs as she walks out of the flat, Aarna following closely behind, with the duvet, mood lighting and her phone. They enter Meera's flat.

INT. Meera's Flat (506) - NIGHT

They enter the flat, Aarna deposits the duvet on the couch, and follows Meera into the kitchen.

MEERA

You know how to cook?

AARNA

Uhm, I can make noodles.

MEERA (sighs)

(pause) Can you chop vegetables?

AARNA

Uhm, yeah, I can try.

MEERA

Great! I'll get you the vegetables, and you can get started.

AARNA

What are we making?

MEERA

Something simple so you don't mess it up. Fried rice

Meera says with a smile on her face. CUT to both of them standing in the kitchen, the pan with sautéed vegetables on fire, spices everywhere, Aarna's finger bleeding and covered with a cloth. Meera's face looks dead, and Aarna simultaneously looks pained and mortified.

MEERA

How the fuck-

AARNA

Here I thought you were supposed to be some kind of master chef.

MEERA (glare)

I gave you one job.

(pause)

You go sit on the table. I'll fix this mess and then you.

Aarna walks away to the table with a nod. Meera takes the pan off the fire and sets it off. When the fire is out, she scrapes out the burnt food and leaves the pan to soak in some water. She cleans the counter, discards all the waste, and puts the cut vegetables in some containers and stores them in her fridge.

When she's done, she gestures for Aarna to come to the bathroom. When they're both in there, she gestures for Aarna to get on the sink counter and takes the first aid kit from under the sink. She runs her finger under running water, using some soap around the cut to clean it. She pats it dry with a clean cloth and wraps it with gauze and bandage cloth, shushing Aarna quietly whenever she hisses in pain.

MEERA

There. All done.

AARNA

Thanks.

MEERA

Next time, if you don't know how to do something, just tell me. I'd rather you just sit on the counter and watch me cook than sever your hand off.

AARNA

Okay, it wasn't that bad.

MEERA

Tell that to my kitchen you almost burnt down.

Aarna rolls her eyes and gets off the counter and goes to the living room, Meera following right behind her. They settle on the couch, and Meera picks her phone up to order food.

MEERA

What do you want to eat?

AARNA

Anything as long as it's your treat

MEERA

You know it is. So what do you want?

AARNA

Hmm, I'm really craving some wings.

MEERA

Alright then. Wings and a pizza?

AARNA

Ooo yes, thanks!

MEERA (smiles)

So what are we watching?

AARNA

A terrible romcom. You get to choose now.

MEERA

Hmm, how about How To Lose A Guy In 10 Days.

AARNA

Oh yes! Oh my god, I love that one.

They play the movie and settle down, both of them on the other end of Meera's sofa, each covered in their duvets. They sit still, watching the movie, saying nothing except a few sarcastic remarks every now and then. At the 40 minute mark, the food gets delivered, and they put the food in the middle of the couch and eat it. Their fingers brush once, but they ignore it. Soon, the food is gone, and they're watching the movie again.

Soon, without realising, they find themselves inching towards each other. Aarna's legs are in Meera's lap, then she shifts closer and as the movie's credits roll, Meera yawns and realises that Aarna fell asleep on her shoulder. She smiles and runs her fingers through her hair a few times, stopping when Meera stirs and slowly goes back to sleep.

Meera lays her down, covering her with a duvet, and gets off the couch. She sits in the armchair next to the couch and covers herself with her own duvet and drifts off.

EXT. City Streets - EVENING

It is evening. Meera just got off work. She is walking in the streets of the city, walking to their apartment, when she gets a call from Aarna.

MEERA
Hello?

AARNA (PHONE)
Are you busy?

MEERA
Just got off work. What's up?

AARNA
The fast food place down the street got a new item on their menu.
Wanna go check it out?

MEERA
Uhh now?

AARNA
Yeah

MEERA
Yeah sure, why not. I'll be there in ten

AARNA
Okay, come quick, I'm already here.

Meera huffs a breath and begins walking, just a tad bit quicker than she did previously. A few minutes later, she finds the place Aarna was talking about and enters it.

INT. Fast Food Place - EVENING

She enters the fast food place and finds Aarna sitting in one of the corner booths, sipping at a Sprite. She looks up as Meera walks over to her, both sporting grins.

MEERA
Oh wow, you look like shit.

AARNA
Hello to you too. And for your information, I've been at uni since 8 AM. I think I deserve some grace.

MEERA (smiles)
So what are we having?

AARNA

I ordered a burger set for the two of us, and the new cheesecake flavor they put out. Apparently it's a mix of strawberry and caramel. Let's see how that turns out.

MEERA

Ooo, it sounds good.

AARNA

Mhmm

Quick montage scenes of audioless dialogue as they talk about their day, what annoyed them, and what made them smile. They get their food, and they eat. While they were talking, Meera's eyes drifted to the side, gazing out the window with a wry smile. She snaps out of it when she sees Aarna's hand shake in front of her.

MEERA

Huh?

AARNA

Did you even listen to anything I just told you?

MEERA

O-Of course, yes. Continue

AARNA

Liar. What were you thinking of?

MEERA

It's nothing.

AARNA

Come onnn, tell meeee

MEERA

It's just that - I used to come to places like this when I was younger.

AARNA

With your friends?

MEERA(shakes her head, smile almost gone, sad)
With someone.

Aarna senses the shift in the mood and opens her phone to show a picture she's taken today. It's a picture of a bird on her hood, her face a dramatic grimace, eyes wide open.

AARNA

Here, look. I wanna show you something.

MEERA (burst into laughter)

Oh my god! Haha, what is that?

AARNA

It harassed me until I gave up my fries and then asserted its dominance over me.

Meera continues laughing, hand coming up to cover the lower part of the face, warm and sincere. Aarna can't help the smile that etches on her face, mirroring hers.

CUT

INT. Museum - EVENING

Aarna finally takes up Meera's offer to work a gig at the museum. Quick shots and progression of Aarna, looking nervous at first and then slowly walking around the place, taking pictures of the gig. Every now and then, she sneaks in a few pictures of Meera, laughing, explaining, or simply in her zone.

Aarna is in the process of being complimented by the gig organizer for her work when Meera pops in behind her. She looks at the pictures on Aarna's laptop as the organizer leaves. Meera puts a hand on her shoulder and leans in, smiling at the work, when something catches her eye. She points at a picture

MEERA

Can I see that?

AARNA (hesitant)

Uhm sure.

It is a picture of Meera mid-laugh, talking to some visitors about a painting on the wall. Meera's eyes zero in on the picture and she smiles. The hand on Aarna's shoulder squeezes it.

MEERA

Wow, Aarna. You're really good.

AARNA

Thanks.

MEERA

Seriously. I never looked so good in any of my pictures.

AARNA

Maybe that's cuz you haven't been photographed by the right person.

MEERA

It matters?

AARNA

Of course! The angle and technique is one thing, but the person behind the camera needs to truly care about the subject to get the best possible outcome-

Aarna looks up, mid-ramble, and stops, finding Meera staring at her, her gaze warm and sincere. Aarna mirrors her smile with one of her own, only to be broken when Meera pinches her cheek.

MEERA

You're so cute.

CUT

INT. Hallway - EVENING

Meera is walking in the hallway, just returning from taking the trash out. She's in her shorts, a t-shirt, and a bun. She enters her apartment, and she gets a call from Aarna.

MEERA

Hello

AARNA

Heyy, where are you right now?

MEERA

My flat, why?

AARNA

Are you busy?

MEERA

No, what's wrong, Aarna?

AARNA

So uh, I was eating out at a cafe, but then I realised I forgot my wallet, so uhh

MEERA

Seriously Aarna?

AARNA

Could you please come get me?

MEERA

Send me the location of the cafe and stay right there.

AARNA

Hah, can't leave even if I wanted to,

Meera rushes into the flat, puts on sweats instead of shorts, messily combs her hair into a ponytail, grabs her stuff, exits the building, and walks to the cafe.

INT. Cafe - EVENING

Meera enters the cafe and spots Aarna at one of the tables. She approaches her to scold and pay for her.

MEERA

I can't believe you forgot your wallet.

AARNA (sheepish)

Uhm, actually, I didn't

MEERA (eyebrow raise)

What?

AARNA (sheepish)

I had my wallet with me.

MEERA

Then why'd you make me come all the way here?

AARNA
Uhm, it's actually my birthday..?
(silence)

AARNA
I wanted to spend it with you, but didn't know how to get you to come
here, so I lied.

MEERA (sitting)
You could've called me like a normal person - and, birthday?
Why did you not tell me?

AARNA
I don't know, actually. But now I know I wanted to spend it with you,
so.

Slow mo scenes of them cutting a tiny cake, Meera singing the song,
Aarna blowing the candle, Meera putting some frosting on Aarna's
face, Aarna squealing, and them taking a picture at the end.

EXT. Streets - NIGHT

They're both walking back from the cafe, leftover cake in a cardboard
box hanging between them. They're laughing and slightly stumbling
into each other as they pass a bookstore. A few seconds later, a
voice calls out. It's a man.

MAN
Meera?

Meera freezes and slowly turns back and looks at the man. The man is
wearing a shirt and dress pants, hair slightly tousled. His face is
furrowed, confused at seeing Meera here.

MAN
Meera? That's you, isn't it?

The man steps closer. Meera stays frozen, rigid, body too tense like
she's afraid and is going to run away at any moment.

MAN
It's been a long time

(steps closer)

MAN
Can we talk?

MEERA
No.

With that, she walks away, not even sparing a glance at the man, not Aarna, who just follows behind her, quick to catch up.

AARNA
Who was that guy?

MEERA
No one.

(silence)

AARNA
Thanks for coming, by the way.

She sneaks a hand between them and grabs Meera's hand, who goes tense at first, but slowly relaxes into it as Aarna starts rubbing circles on her knuckles. Aarna smiles, Meera tries to mirror it, and only partially succeeds.

The next few days pass by slowly. Meera has not been talking to Aarna properly, and while Aarna understands that man was not welcome in Meera's life, she needs to understand the reason why. But Aarna has not gotten a chance to properly talk to her ever since her birthday.

Quick shots of her trying to knock on the wall, her dorm call out to her, nothing works. She's walking home after her university, dawdling with her headphones on. She stops when she sees a hand come in the line of her vision. She hunches one of her shoulders and tries to pull herself away from the intruder. She removes her headphones and looks at the man.

MAN
Aarna?

AARNA

I'm sorry, do I know you?

MAN

This is going to sound a bit strange, but you're Meera's friend, right?

AARNA

Who are you? And how do you know my name?

MAN

I'm Jatin, Meera's ex-husband. I tried talking to her a few nights ago. I think you were there too.

AARNA (cold)

Oh. That was you.

MAN

I really want to talk to her and try to make things right, but she changed her number and won't talk to me. Could you please help me?

AARNA

No. Why do you think she wants to talk to you after literally going through all those lengths to *not* talk to you?

MAN

I know she doesn't want to talk to me. That's why I need your help.

AARNA

Dude, don't even. If she doesn't want to talk to you, then she doesn't. Simple as that, now leave me alone.

MAN

Wait! I don't know what she told you about me, but remember that there are always two sides to a story. I know I don't deserve her trust, but I know she's been struggling. I thought maybe someone who actually knows her could help.

AARNA

Piss off, dude.

MAN

Does she still work at the museum?

Aarna ignores him and walks away to her apartment. She enters her flat and is at the threshold of the house when she hesitates. She

drops her stuff near the shoe rack and goes to Meera's flat and rings the bell. She doesn't answer. She keeps ringing the bell.

AARNA

Meera! I need to talk to you!

She rings the bell one more time when Meera opens the door, a little annoyed. Aarna takes in her pale and ashen complexion, dark circles under her eyes, and messy hair. She looks like she hasn't slept well in a while.

AARNA

Meera.. What happened to you?

MEERA

Nothing

AARNA

You don't have to pretend everything's okay. You can talk to me.

MEERA

Leave it, Aarna.

She's about to close the door when Aarna says

AARNA

It's cuz of the guy, isn't it?

(Pause)

Jatin. He came looking for me today. Asked me about you?

MEERA

What? What did he ask?

AARNA

He wanted to know how to contact you and where you worked and-

MEERA

And what did you tell him?!

AARNA

N-Nothing!

MEERA

Tell me the truth, Aarna.

AARNA

I'm not lying! I told him to piss off and

MEERA

Did you tell him where I work?

AARNA

No.

MEERA

Where I live?

AARNA

No! I didn't tell him anything!

AARNA

Meera, what's going on? Let me help, please-

MEERA

You can't help me, Aarna

AARNA

Meera, you're clearly terrified of him.

MEERA

Aarna-

AARNA

You clearly haven't slept well in days, and you stopped talking to me completely- why are you shutting yourself away-

MEERA

Stop.

AARNA

We can figure this out-

MEERA

I said stop!

Aarna stops speaking. Meera looks away, trying to steady her breathing.

MEERA

I don't want him anywhere near me.

AARNA

Okay

MEERA

I don't want to see him, talk to him, or have him know anything about me. (pause) I don't want anything to do with him.

AARNA

Okay.

MEERA

So please, for my sake, leave it alone.

AARNA

Okay, I won't. But you don't have to go through this alone, Meera.

Meera's expression softens very little, and then she looks away, closing the door.

MEERA

Bye, Aarna.

And then she closes the door. Aarna remains in the hallway, staring at the door,

INT. Museum - DAY

Meera walks through the museum floor, carrying a clipboard. She walks around, looking at the visitors. She looks tired, but still professional. She stops beside a group of visitors and begins explaining a painting. Her voice trails off as she notices Jatin standing at the doorway across the gallery. She freezes, the voices around her begin to become numb, her own fast heartbeat echoing loudly in her ears. He is standing in front of a sculpture of a mother and her kid. The voices dull down until there's nothing but her breathing and heartbeat.

FLASHBACK

INT. Jatin's Family's House - NIGHT - YEARS AGO

Meera and Jatin are sitting next to each other at the dining table, rigid and tense. Jatin's parents sit across them, their food lies untouched in front of them. She is about to reach for her food when Jatin's mother speaks

JATIN'S MOTHER

How much longer are we supposed to wait?

MEERA (freezes)

I'm sorry?

JATIN'S MOTHER

You heard me

JATIN

Ma-

JATIN'S MOTHER

No, let her speak.

Meera stays quiet.

JATIN'S FATHER

We've been patient. It's been 2 years.

MEERA

I know-

JATIN'S MOTHER

Do you? A marriage is supposed to have a baby.

(silence)

What's the point of this marriage if you can't even give him a child?

(Meera's eyes flicker towards Jatin, who is not looking at her.)

MEERA

We're trying

JATIN'S MOTHER

You've been trying for years.

JATIN'S MOTHER

If we'd known the problem was you, that you were the reason this family can't have an heir, then we would never have agreed to this alliance.

JATIN

Ma-

JATIN'S MOTHER

Stay out of this.

Meera stares at Jatin, eyes pleading, to do something, say something, but Jatin says nothing. Doesn't even look at her.

INT. Bedroom - NIGHT - YEARS AGO

Meera stands by the window. Jatin has just entered the room. He closes the door behind him.

MEERA

Why didn't you say anything?

JATIN

Meera-

MEERA

You just sat there and watched them belittle me. Like I'm nothing but- but a machine to birth a child-

JATIN

What was I supposed to do?

MEERA

Say something, do something, but show that you were in support of me!

JATIN

Meera, they are my parents.

MEERA

And I'm your wife!

Jatin doesn't say anything. Meera laughs, hollow.

MEERA

Of course

She turns away.

INT. Hospital - DAY

Meera is sitting on a white chair, alone in the room. Her hands tremble in her lap. A doctor sits next to her. The conversation audio is not audible, but Meera's face changes to despair.

INT. Jatin's Family Home - NIGHT

Jatin's mother places a photograph of a child on the table. It was the picture of the son of her first son.

JATIN'S MOTHER

At least someone in this family knows how to do what she's supposed to.

Meera's face falls, and she looks at Jatin, but again, there's nothing.

INT. Bedroom - NIGHT

Jatin enters the room and sees Meera packing a suitcase. Jatin stands by the door.

JATIN

Are you really leaving? Over this?

MEERA

No.

She slowly turns toward him.

MEERA

I'm leaving because I can't stand this anymore. All the time you just let it happen. You don't even take a stand for me.

Jatin doesn't respond.

MEERA

Jatin, I could bear them making those remarks on me, and I could bear them belittling me. What I cannot bear is you watching them do it.

She closes the suitcase, removes the ring and walks past him.

CUT TO PRESENT

Meera is still staring at Jatin. She doesn't spare him another glance and just sprints away from there, out the gate, onto the streets and into her apartment. She closes her door and leans against it. She hears knocking on it, and her eyes widen. But then a voice comes through

AARNA

Meera! Are you okay?

She doesn't answer, just focuses on calming her breathing

AARNA

Meera, please

(silence)

AARNA

I just want to talk, please.

Meera opens the door and looks at Aarna.

AARNA

Hey

MEERA

What do you want?

AARNA

Are you okay? You looked really scared so I-

MEERA

You shouldn't have talked to him.

AARNA

What?

MEERA

Jatin. You talked to him

AARNA

Yeah, cuz he stopped me and asked me. But I didn't tell him anything.

MEERA

Then how did he find me at the museum?

AARNA

He came to the museum?

MEERA

Don't act surprised! You were the only person he talked to!

AARNA

That you know of!

MEERA

Aarna-

AARNA

Meera, I swear. I told him nothing. Nothing about where you worked, lived, or anything.

MEERA

But he found me-

AARNA

Meera, maybe he found it online? A website or something? But I would never tell him anything. Not when I knew you didn't want to talk to him.

MEERA

Oh, you think you know me so well, don't you? Trying to make decisions for me, trying to fix my life-

AARNA

Meera, when have I done that?

MEERA

You're doing it now! Trying to fix whatever you think is wrong - is broken with me

AARNA

I don't think anything is wrong with you, Meera. I just want to know what's bothering you cuz I want to help you

MEERA

Don't then! It's none of your fucking business!

AARNA

It is my business, Meera. We're friends, and when you're hurting-

MEERA

Friends? (laughs bitterly) please. All this bullshit about- about

happy endings and relationships, I don't do that crap.

AARNA

So what, all that we had the past few months was, what? An act? You want me to believe that?

MEERA

I don't care if you believe it or not, that's the truth.

AARNA

It's not. I know you, Meera. You can't fake something like that

MEERA

So just cuz you know me for a few months, you've got me all figured out, huh?

(pause)

MEERA

Aarna, I need you to understand that this was temporary, like everything in life. And this is just coming to an end now.

AARNA

No, I don't believe you. You don't think that- you think that you don't deserve a happy ending. Every time someone gets close to you, you shut them out, not cuz it's temporary, Meera- it's cuz you're scared.

MEERA

You don't know anything about me, Aarna, the things I had to endure-

AARNA

And I'm out here, telling you that I'm willing to understand you, but you don't listen! You let some asshole from the past show up and ruin everything we've built over these last few months!

MEERA

Please Aarna

AARNA

Meera, please. I'm here for you. And if I don't understand that help me! Help me understand.

MEERA

Aarna, I don't want to talk about it.

AARNA

That's fine! I don't mind. I'll stay here, however long you need me to. Just don't shut me out like this! Don't tell me none of this mattered to you.

Silence

MEERA

Maybe it didn't, Aarna!

They both go silent. Meera looks away, regretting it.

AARNA

Okay.

MEERA

Aarna-

AARNA

No, it's okay. (she swallows) I understand

Aarna turns to leave and walks to her flat. She turns the doorknob and turns back to Meera

AARNA

You know what? Maybe you were right.

MEERA

Huh?

AARNA

Happy endings.

AARNA

They're not for everyone

With that, Aarna goes back inside her flat, leaving Meera alone in the corridor, as tears begin to well up in her eyes.

INT. Hallway - EVENING

It is the day after the argument. Aarna is coming back from university. She glances at Meera's door for a second before continuing back to her flat. She unlocks the door and steps in but freezes when she notices an envelope near the shoe rack. Confused, she picks it up, goes to her table and sits down, dropping her bag. She opens the envelope and begins reading it.

Dear Aarna,

You're probably wondering why I left you a letter. Well, it contains all the things I ever wanted to tell but couldn't.

Well, to start it all off, I want to say I'm sorry. For everything I said yesterday. And you're probably angry at me, and you have every right to be.

And, maybe at this point of the letter you're gonna want to run to my flat and demand I say it all to your face, but please don't. Though on any other day I would love for you to run into my arms, now, you wouldn't find me there.

I am sorry, Aarna, but I left. And I know I should've left you with a proper goodbye.

But please understand that I did not leave cuz I stopped caring about you. I left cuz I cared too much for you. And maybe that's the problem.

When I first moved in here, I did not expect to make any connections. I just expected to live my life alone and do well in my job. But then I saw you, on the very first day. Somehow, without me even realizing it, you and your unhealthy eating habits, too bright clothes, and messy buns became part of my life. Our wall time became something I looked forward to every day, and it didn't matter if you just yelled at me across the concrete or we sang sweet melodies.

And I was almost too afraid to admit this, but you became something familiar. A routine. You became my home.

I don't even know when all this happened.

I don't even know when I started caring for you.

Love. If it were me from a few years ago, I would be terrified.

Terrified of giving my all only to be ripped apart from the core.
But for some reason, being in love with you didn't make me feel
scared.

It made me look forward to every day.

And maybe that's what's scarier.

And when someone becomes your everything, from your heart to your
soul, they can get the chance to hurt you, and Aarna, I am sorry,
but I am too scared to go through all that again.

I spent so long convincing myself that I didn't need someone to
feel whole, that being alone was easier. But then you came and
unraveled all the work I've spent years trying to build up.

You made me laugh, made me joke, and you made me want things
again.

And now I hate that I have to leave you. I hate that I have to
build everything from the ground up again.

And most of all, I hate that the one person who made me feel so
safe and like myself for a long while is the one I'm walking away
from.

But, Aarna, know this. You didn't do anything wrong. You never
did. I think deep down even I knew that yesterday. But I was
scared and angry, and you didn't deserve that. You were kind to
me when I was pushing you away. And you continued to be kind
through it all.

Aarna, you are so kind and easy to be around. I hope you know
that. And I hope you never let anyone convince you otherwise.

You are so so easy to love. You make people want to stay. You
make people want to change into a better version of themselves.

And you deserve someone who stays. Not someone who leaves you
with a letter cuz they were too much of a coward to say all this
in person.

I don't know how to be that person. I really wish I did, but I
don't.

Maybe one day I will, and when that day comes, I hope we cross paths again. In different circumstances, and maybe our story will be different.

So, Aarna, please don't wait for me or go looking for me. You won't find me. And don't blame yourself for this. You gave me more than I could ever ask for.

*I am going to miss you so much.
I am going to miss your stupid jokes, your stupid socks, your piano, and your off-key singing. I'm gonna miss you asking how my day was. I am going to miss hearing about all the mundane things in your life.*

Oh, and please continue doing photography. Don't ever fucking give that up.

Make yourself happy like you made me happy.

I love you

And I'm sorry

- Meera

Meera is sobbing by the time she's done reading the letter. She clutches the letter close to her chest and lets the tears fall. For the next few days, she's a mess. She's got missed deadlines, absences, and assignments all piling up on her, but for her it doesn't matter. She just stares at the wall opposite her.

This goes on for a few days. Then she glances at the camera on the table and the frames on her wall. She wipes her tears and gets up.

MEERA

She wants me to succeed and be happy? Then I'll fucking do it.

She opens up a new browser page and CUT TO BLACK.

INT. Museum Inauguration - MORNING (6 years later)

The museum is crowded. People move through the galleries, admiring the collection. Meera is standing near the gallery entrance and greeting people. She looks confident and composed in her black dress. She is now the director of the museum. She turns to greet another guest, but from the corner of her eye, she finds a familiar person. She looks, and it's AARNA. She looks more confident, older. Her hair is neatly styled, unlike her usual messy hair. And what catches Meera's eye is the black strap of a camera hanging as a contrast against her bright red dress. Their eyes lock, and for a moment no one moves. Aarna looks at her, almost like she wants Meera to make the first move.

Meera walks over to where Aarna is. She smiles when she sees Meera.

AARNA

Hi

MEERA

Hi

(long silence)

AARNA

You're still dressed like depression, I see.

MEERA

And you're still dressed like a rainbow vomited on you, I see.

Aarna smiles and looks at her.

AARNA

It's called having a personality. You should try it once.

MEERA

The only thing you're accomplishing is giving everyone a headache cuz of how bright your clothes are.

Silence falls between them. The smiles are still on their faces, but Meera looks away, smile faltering a bit.

MEERA

I.. I'm sorry

Aarna's smile fades a bit.

AARNA
For what?

MEERA
You know what.

AARNA
Meera, I forgave you a long time ago.

MEERA
Still, I feel it's only proper to apologize in person.

AARNA
You don't have to keep apologizing.

She looks Meera in the eye

AARNA
I forgive you.

Meera nods

AARNA
I still have your letter, by the way.

MEERA (surprised)
What?

AARNA (mischievous)
It's framed

MEERA
Oh come on. The entire purpose of that letter was to move on. Not
stay stuck on it.

AARNA
How could I? When you said all those things and left me with hope of
something in the future.

(silence)

AARNA

You told me you cared for me. That I was your everything. How could I just forget that?

(pause)

AARNA

Did you mean everything you said in that letter?

MEERA

Yes.

AARNA

Everything?

MEERA

Every single word.

AARNA (nods)

And do you still feel that way?

MEERA

About caring for you?

Aarna nods

MEERA

Never stopped feeling that way.

Aarna's lips part in surprise as her breath hitches.

MEERA

About not being ready?

No.

Aarna's eyes widen just a little, hope starting to fill her eyes.

AARNA

So...

(steps closer)

The "Maybe one day I'll be that strong person" version of you.. Is the one standing in front of me?

Meera nods.

AARNA (slightly relieved)
Jeez (pause), what took you so long?

MEERA
Hey, I had to become a better version of myself for you!

AARNA
And it took 6 years?

MEERA (smile)
Apparently

AARNA
Oh shut up. Here I was thinking I'll need to be old and wrinkled for
you to come back to me.

MEERA
Oh, stop being so dramatic

AARNA
I'm not being dramatic! That's how it felt!

MEERA
You framed my goodbye letter!

AARNA
Ugh whatever.

Meera laughs, and Aarna joins in eventually. It's still awkward, but
there's also hope for a new beginning. Aarna glances at the entry to
the gallery.

AARNA
So...

MEERA
So?

AARNA
If you still feel that way, do you wanna go to the-

MEERA
- fast food place down the street?

Aarna stops, a little shocked. Meera grins.

MEERA

The moment this event ends, we're getting out of here.

AARNA (laughs)

Alright, Ms. Museum Director.

MEERA

Ohh, don't think I haven't noticed, Ms Photographer. A whole dman studio?

Aarna laughs

AARNA

Well, someone told me I had to put myself out there to get better at stuff.

(pause, look at Meera)

So I did. Guess it worked out.

MEERA

Hmm, whoever told that must've been smart.

AARNA

Oh shut up.

They both giggle, the awkwardness is still there, but it doesn't feel like it used to. Aarna starts walking away, and then turns back

AARNA (smile)

Don't disappear on me again.

MEERA

I won't

Aarna walks away, and Meera watches her go, smiling to herself.
CUT TO BLACK